task of vetting and weeding out ineligible applicants starts on February 8.

Finding the funds will obviously be a somewhat more onerous task—several schemes involve direct benefit transfer of cash. Officials are already putting together details of loans raised by the state and individual departments between June 2014 (when the state came into being) and December 2023 for a stock-taking of state finances.



ANI

WELFARE CM Reddy launches the Maha Lakshmi Scheme, offering free bus travel to women, in Hyderabad, Dec 2023

Telangana proposes to raise Rs 13,000 crore through open market borrowings (OMBs) between January and March. It had raised Rs 42,551 crore in the first nine months of FY24.

The state government has opted to raise loans in spite of the restrictions imposed by the Union finance ministry on such borrowings. The 15th Finance Commission had set a ceiling of 29.5 per cent of GSDP for total outstanding liabilities, but with off-budget borrowings (OBBs), the percentage could hit 38.1 per cent for Telangana this year. In sectors like energy and irrigation, the drain on resources is huge. Telangana's profligate power utilities have amassed losses worth some Rs 81,000 crore since its formation in 2014.

The Revanth Reddy administration has also ordered inquiries into the allegations of corruption against the former Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) government in major projects, including the Kaleshwaram lift irrigation scheme. A reorganisation of the 33 districts into "fewer viable administrative units" is also on the cards, says Revanth, as "many districts were irrationally carved out by a monarch [ex-CM K. Chandrashekar Rao or KCR]". The CM has also shuffled the bureaucracy around (but has taken care to not seem vindictive) and is relying on a fresh team at his office.

Unlike KCR's daggers drawn face-off with the Centre, Revanth is also pursuing cordial Centre-state relations, calling on Prime Minister Narendra Modi on December 26 with a wish-list for the state. The CM is also trying not to antagonise governor Tamilisai Sounderarajan. He has also set aside time thrice a week to discuss constituency issues with the MLAs. This is apart from the Rs 10 crore special development fund promise for each constituency.

It's early days, but Revanth will also have to manage any dissent in the party. There are several leaders who sacrificed their claims in the state elections and will want their pound of flesh. There are also many claimants for the three Rajya Sabha vacancies coming up in March, not to mention the six vacancies in the Legislative Council. "Revanth has been cautious in his first few weeks. A major marker, as of now, has been the delegating of authority. He's been like a team player to both the bureaucracy and cabinet colleagues," observes Prof. Harathi Vageeshan of NALSAR University, Hyderabad.

Meanwhile, preparations for the Lok Sabha polls continue. Only three Congress candidates won in 2019 and it'll be an uphill task wresting seats from the BRS and the BJP, the two other big players in the fray. The state Congress has requested ex-party president Sonia Gandhi to contest from the state, which could also provide a boost. The plan is to make it a BRS versus Congress contest and relegate the BJP to the background (in 2019, the BRS had won nine seats and the BJP four). The saffron party may have different ideas, though. It won eight seats in the recent assembly polls and came second in 19 others.

Revanth, who has had stints in the right-wing Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) before joining the Congress, took over as the state unit chief in 2021 when the morale of the cadre had hit rock bottom. Less than two years later, he steered the party to a big win in Telangana. It's been a great start, now he'll have to sustain the aggression and deliver on his promises. ■

A GOOD START

- **CM Revanth has started well, but funds for the '6G' promises will be an ask**
- **The CM is for now trying a non-confrontational approach with the Centre**
- **Managing the Congress state unit is a challenge**